

Fern

What did vegetarian dinosaurs have for breakfast, lunch, and dinner? Ferns! Most of the plants we see today did not yet exist, so ferns were often on the prehistoric menu. You still find ferns in dark, wet places all over the world, often on forest floors.

Ferns are easily recognizable from their feathery fronds. Each leaf starts in a tightly curled coil at the fern's centre before unrolling into a long triangle. Some ferns grow on a "trunk" of their old roots, and these tree ferns can be very tall – the soft tree fern can grow as high as a giraffe. Other ferns grow high up on trees, to help them reach the sunlight in dense forests.

Soft tree fern,
Australia



Coal is made from ancient ferns and other prehistoric plants – squashed into rock over millions of years.